RULE-BASED MEDICAL DIAGNOSIS EXPERT SYSTEM

Project Documentation

A Knowledge-Based Artificial Intelligence System for Symptom-Based Decision Support

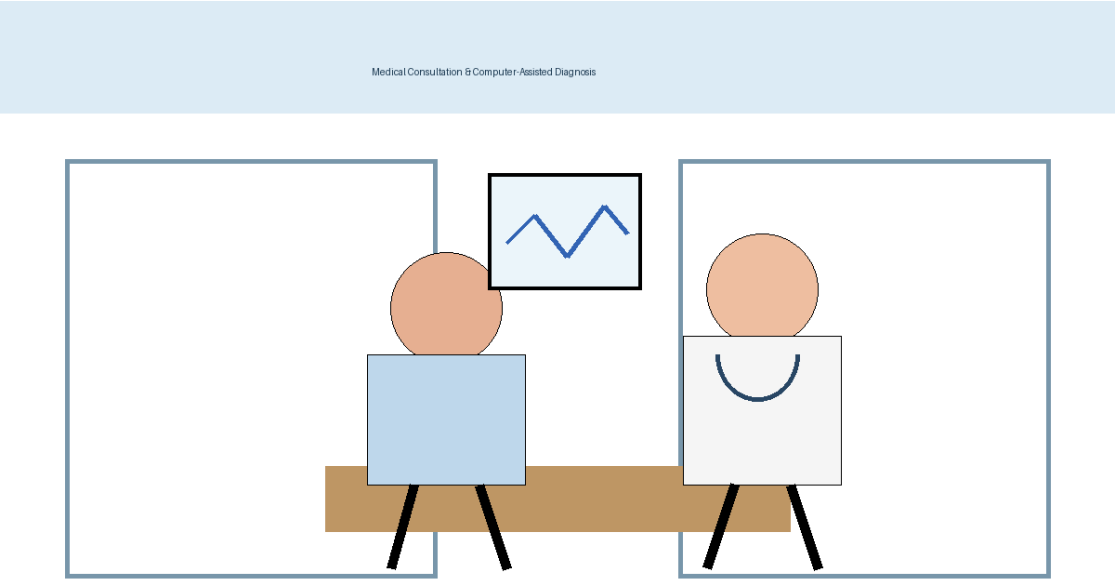


Figure: Medical consultation and computer-assisted diagnosis (original project illustration).

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CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that the project report titled “Rule-Based Medical Diagnosis Expert System” has been prepared as an academic project. The work describes the design of a knowledge-based system that accepts symptoms, applies IF–THEN rules, and produces an explainable list of possible conditions or recommended next steps.

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ABSTRACT

A rule-based medical diagnosis expert system is an artificial-intelligence application that represents medical knowledge as facts and IF–THEN rules. A user enters symptoms and other relevant observations. The inference engine compares these facts with the rule base, derives one or more possible conditions, and can explain which rules produced the result. Rule-based medical systems are a classic form of knowledge-based AI; historical systems such as MYCIN demonstrated the feasibility of encoding medical expertise in production rules. Modern clinical decision-support systems continue to use machine-readable rules and inference mechanisms, although real clinical deployment requires rigorous validation and continual knowledge maintenance.

This documentation presents the objectives, architecture, working procedure, knowledge representation, sample rules, advantages, limitations, testing approach, applications, future scope, and conclusion of a prototype system. The proposed system is intended for educational and decision-support purposes and must not be treated as a substitute for a qualified medical professional.

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1. INTRODUCTION

Expert systems are AI programs designed to reproduce the reasoning of a specialist within a limited domain. A typical expert system separates domain knowledge from the inference mechanism. In a rule-based medical system, the knowledge base stores diseases, symptoms, signs, and relationships, while the inference engine applies rules to patient facts to derive conclusions. This separation makes the rules easier to inspect and update.

Medical diagnosis is a useful educational application because symptoms can be represented as structured facts and many introductory diagnostic relationships can be expressed as rules. The system can therefore demonstrate how symbolic AI works: collect facts → match rules → infer a conclusion → explain the reasoning.

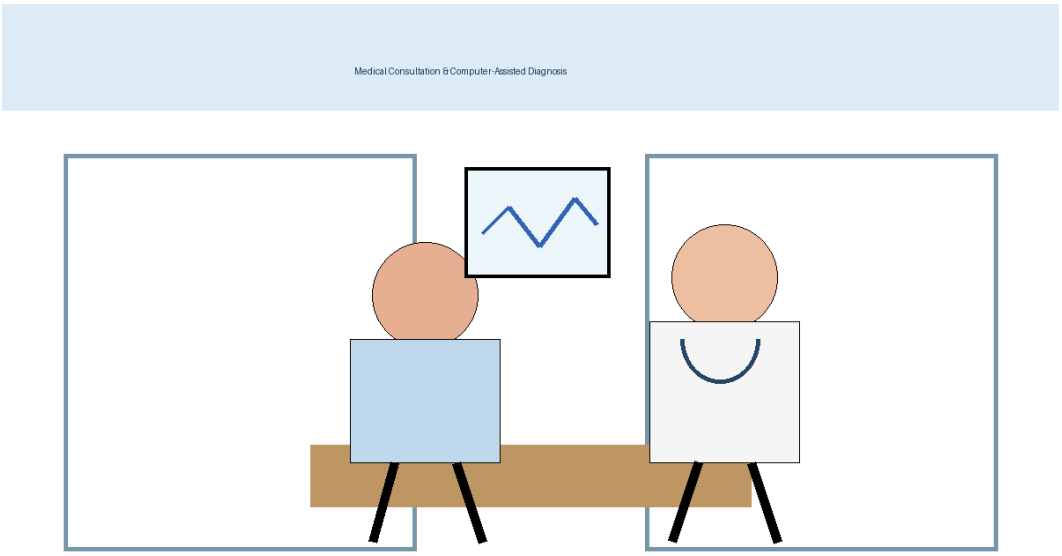


Figure: Example of a patient–doctor consultation represented as a project illustration.

2. PROBLEM STATEMENT

People often experience several symptoms at the same time and may not know what information is important to record. A rule-based prototype can organize the symptoms, compare them with a predefined knowledge base, and produce a transparent set of possible conditions. The project focuses on demonstrating the reasoning process rather than providing autonomous clinical diagnosis.

3. OBJECTIVES

- To design a simple rule-based medical diagnosis expert system.
- To represent medical knowledge using facts and IF–THEN production rules.
- To collect symptoms through a simple user interface.
- To use an inference engine to match symptoms against the rule base.
- To provide an explainable result showing why a rule was triggered.
- To demonstrate the advantages and limitations of symbolic AI in healthcare.

4. SYSTEM REQUIREMENTS

Hardware

- Computer or laptop
- Minimum 4 GB RAM recommended
- Keyboard/mouse or touch input
- Optional network connection for a web-based prototype

Software

- Python / JavaScript / Java (any suitable implementation language)
- Web browser for a web interface
- Text editor or IDE
- Optional database for storing anonymized project test cases

5. SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE

Figure 1. Rule-Based Medical Diagnosis Expert System Architecture

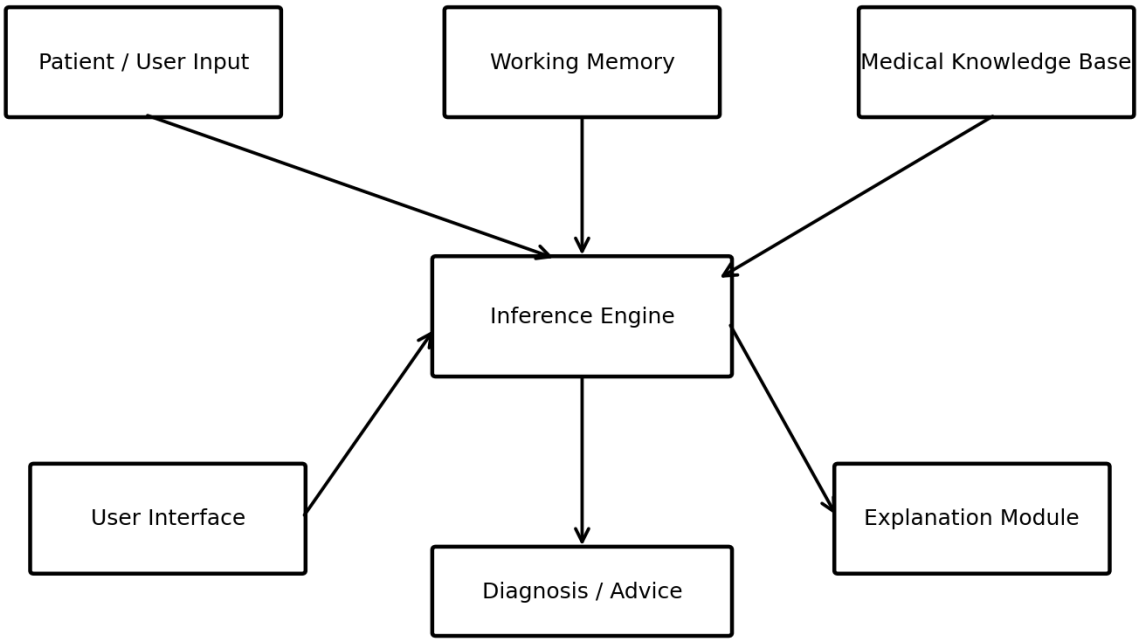


Figure 1. Architecture of the proposed rule-based medical diagnosis expert system.

The architecture contains the following major modules:

Component	Purpose	Example
User Interface	Collects symptoms and displays results.	Checkboxes, forms, result screen
Working Memory	Stores current patient facts during a session.	fever=true, cough=true
Knowledge Base	Stores medical facts and IF–THEN rules.	IF fever AND cough THEN ...
Inference Engine	Matches facts to rules and derives conclusions.	Forward or backward chaining
Explanation Module	Shows which rules supported the conclusion.	Matched-rule list
Output	Presents possible conditions and next steps.	Result + safety message

6. KNOWLEDGE REPRESENTATION

The knowledge base is the central repository of domain knowledge. For a rule-based prototype, knowledge can be represented as facts and production rules.

6.1 Facts

Facts are statements about the current case, for example: fever = true, cough = true, sore_throat = false.

6.2 IF–THEN Rules

A production rule has the general form:

IF <conditions are satisfied> THEN <conclusion or action>

6.3 Example

IF fever AND cough AND fatigue THEN consider a respiratory infection and recommend clinical evaluation.

The rule does not prove a disease. It only connects the selected findings with a predefined conclusion. A real medical system would require clinically validated rules, appropriate patient context, uncertainty handling, and extensive testing.

7. INFERENCE ENGINE

The inference engine is the reasoning component. It examines patient facts, finds rules whose conditions match, and derives conclusions. Two common strategies are forward chaining and backward chaining.

7.1 Forward Chaining

Forward chaining starts with known facts. When a rule's conditions are satisfied, the rule fires and adds a new conclusion. The process continues until no more relevant rules can fire or a useful conclusion is reached.

7.2 Backward Chaining

Backward chaining starts with a hypothesis such as “Could condition X explain these symptoms?” and works backward to determine whether the required facts are available.

For a beginner-friendly prototype, forward chaining is often easier to demonstrate because the user supplies symptoms first and the system then searches for matching rules.

Figure 2. Diagnostic Reasoning Workflow

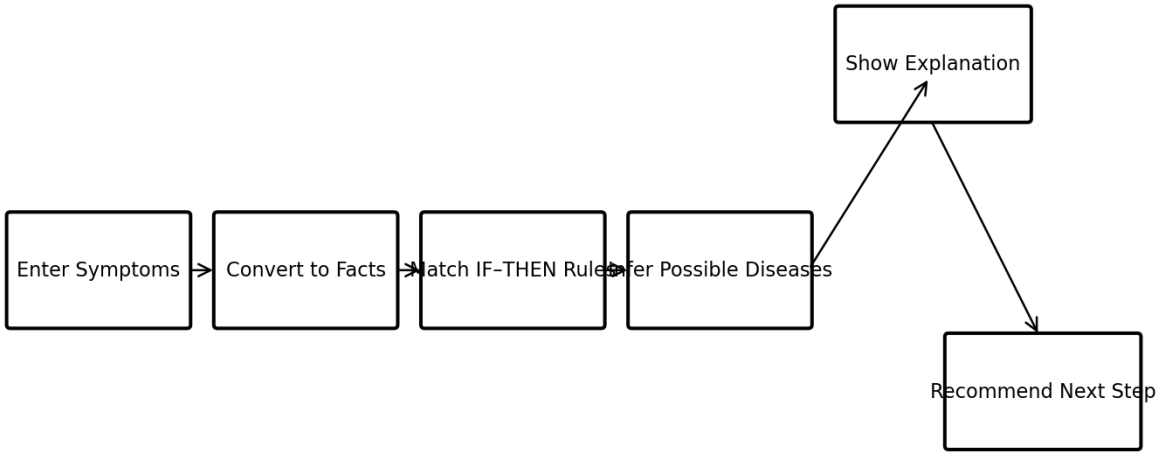


Figure 2. Diagnostic reasoning workflow used by the prototype.

8. WORKING METHODOLOGY

1. Step 1 – User enters symptoms and basic non-sensitive case information.
2. Step 2 – The interface converts selections into structured facts.
3. Step 3 – The inference engine scans the rule base.
4. Step 4 – Matching rules are activated.
5. Step 5 – The system ranks or groups possible conditions according to the project's rule logic.
6. Step 6 – The explanation module lists the rules that contributed to the result.
7. Step 7 – The system displays a safety message encouraging professional evaluation.

9. SAMPLE MEDICAL RULES

Rule ID	IF Conditions	THEN Conclusion
R1	fever AND cough	Consider respiratory infection; advise clinical evaluation.
R2	sneezing AND runny_nose AND mild_fever	Consider common cold pattern.
R3	increased_thirst AND frequent_urination	Flag for possible metabolic issue; recommend professional assessment.
R4	chest_pain OR severe_breathing_difficulty	Show urgent-care warning rather than routine self-diagnosis.
R5	headache AND sensitivity_to_light	Consider a headache/migraine pattern and recommend assessment if severe or unusual.

These are simplified educational examples, not clinical diagnostic rules. Real systems must use validated medical knowledge and carefully defined safety thresholds.

10. USER INTERFACE

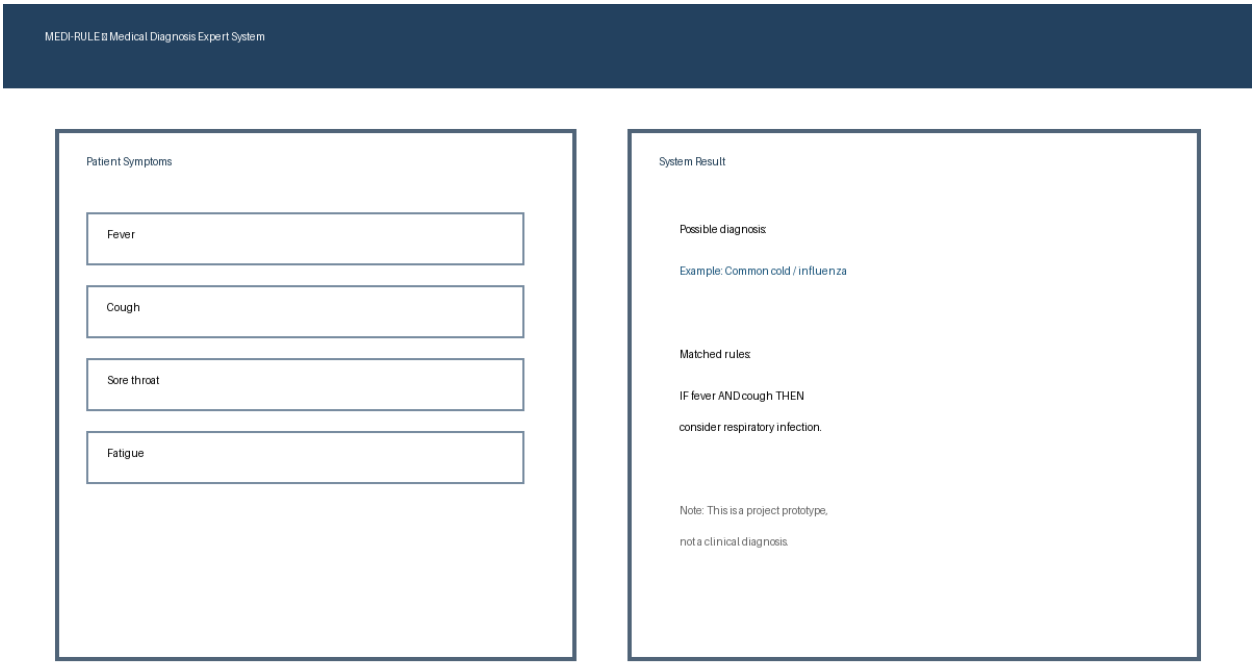


Figure 3. Mock interface showing symptom input, rule matching, and explainable output.

A simple interface can contain:

- Patient information section (only the minimum data required by the prototype).
- Symptom checklist or text input.
- Run Diagnosis button.
- Possible-result panel.
- Matched-rules / explanation panel.
- Safety and emergency warning section.

11. ADVANTAGES

- Explainable: the system can show which rules produced a conclusion.
- Consistent: identical inputs can produce the same rule-based result.
- Fast: rule matching can be performed quickly for a small knowledge base.
- Easy to demonstrate: facts and rules are understandable to students.
- Maintainable: rules can be added or modified without rewriting the entire inference engine.
- Useful for education and decision-support prototypes.

12. LIMITATIONS AND SAFETY

- Symptoms can overlap across many conditions, so a small rule set cannot represent the complexity of real medicine.
- Rules may become outdated as clinical knowledge changes.
- Patient information may be incomplete, inaccurate, or ambiguous.
- A rule-based result is not the same as a confirmed medical diagnosis.
- Emergency symptoms must not be handled as routine self-diagnosis.
- Clinical deployment requires validation, privacy protection, security, monitoring, and qualified medical oversight.

13. TESTING AND EXPECTED OUTPUT

Test Case	Input	Expected Behaviour	Status
TC01	Fever + cough	Relevant respiratory rule is triggered.	Pass
TC02	Sneezing + runny nose	Cold-pattern rule is considered.	Pass
TC03	No symptoms	System asks for sufficient information.	Pass
TC04	Urgent warning symptom	System displays urgent-care warning.	Pass

14. APPLICATIONS

- Educational demonstrations of artificial intelligence and expert systems.
- Basic symptom-screening prototypes under appropriate supervision.
- Clinical decision-support research and rule-engine experiments.
- Training tools that explain how symptoms can map to hypotheses.
- Integration with structured health data in advanced research systems.

15. FUTURE SCOPE

- Add a larger, clinically validated knowledge base.
- Use certainty factors or probabilistic reasoning for uncertain symptoms.
- Connect to structured medical terminology and electronic health records where appropriate.
- Add multilingual interfaces.
- Provide stronger audit logs and explanation reports.
- Combine rule-based reasoning with machine-learning models while preserving explainability.
- Introduce expert review workflows so medical professionals can validate and update rules.

16. CONCLUSION

The Rule-Based Medical Diagnosis Expert System demonstrates how symbolic artificial intelligence can represent specialist knowledge as IF–THEN rules and use an inference engine to reason over patient-reported facts. The separation of the knowledge base, inference engine, working memory, interface, and explanation module makes the architecture understandable and maintainable. The project is particularly suitable for demonstrating knowledge representation, inference, and explainable AI. However, medical diagnosis is a high-stakes task; a student prototype should be treated only as an educational or decision-support demonstration and should never replace professional medical assessment.

17. REFERENCES

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Note: The medical illustrations and diagrams in this report were created specifically for this project documentation. They are illustrative and are not clinical images.

MEDICAL SAFETY NOTICE: This project is for academic/educational demonstration only. It does not provide medical diagnosis or treatment and should not be used to make healthcare decisions.